Choose What's Best for You



PROF. JASKIRAN ARORA

TECHNICAL EDUCATION IS ONE OF the most sought-after choices for higher education as it lays focus on skill development and enhancing the employability of students, setting the way to a rewarding career path. With technological transformation deepening its roots into almost every aspect of our lives, economic transformation shifting the terms of global trade and social transformation changing how we socialise, there is nothing that has remained untouched—how we communicate, bank, travel, shop, read, study and even entertain ourselves. Therefore, technical education is assuming importance like never before.

So, what is that a student should be mindful of when seeking admission into technical programmes? The breadth and depth of the curriculum to widen the foundational base, integration with research opportunities to promote critical thinking, pedagogical interventions to be able to analyse the knowledge gained, and field immersions and exposure to real-world situations to apply the knowledge are the essential attributes.

Breadth and depth of the curriculum: Today technology, management, entrepreneurship and innovation are fusing to offer disruptive solutions to businesses. And therefore, students must review the curriculum of the programmes they want to join—when was it revised last, how well is technology woven into it, what are the opportunities to diversify their base and study multidisciplinary courses, and most importantly what is the focus on enhancing their skills.

Research opportunities: The pace at which knowledge is being created is unprecedented. Unfortunately, India's education system promotes creating conformists and not the ones who question. Opportunities to conduct research promote one's ability to inquire and critique. So, students need to check if they will get such an opportunity and will get to study courses such as critical thinking and problem-solving.

Pedagogical interventions: Students must enquire how technical education is imparted. What percentage of the programme is 'taught' by the teacher and what is that the students 'do' in the classrooms or field? Is there a greater focus on textbooks or are more contemporary case studies taken up and industry speakers called to classrooms? Answers to these questions will help students understand whether the institute is truly preparing the students for an ever-evolving technical landscape.

"The landscape of technical education is evolving rapidly. Industries demand more tech-savvy and adaptable professionals"

Field immersions: Higher education institutes are spaces where the students are buffered from the real world and groomed to face it when they graduate. But even while studying, they must get to have a sneak peek into the real world for them to be better prepared. Field immersions, internships, live projects and apprenticeships provide such opportunities to the students, thereby condensing the time they will take to contribute to the workplaces they later on join.

Technical education is evolving rapidly, as industries demand more tech-savvy and adaptable professionals. Thus, the importance of choosing a technical education programme wisely cannot be overstated in shaping a person's future career endeavours. ■

The author is Dean, Education Quality, BML Munjal University, Gurugram